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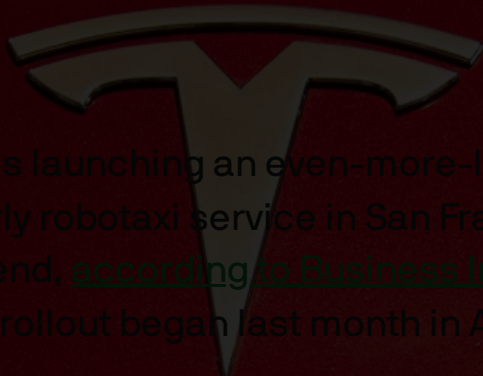
TRANSPORTATION



Tesla wants to bring robotaxis to San Francisco. Here's what's standing in the way.

Sean O'Kane, Kirsten Korosec

4:41 PM PDT · July 25, 2025



Tesla is launching an even-more-limited version of its early robotaxi service in San Francisco this weekend, [according to Business Insider](#), after an initial rollout began last month in Austin, Texas.

The company is testing its robotaxi service in San Francisco. The company is testing its robotaxi service in San Francisco.

Depending on the actions taken, there may be a need for a wheel vehicle.

Two states have approved Tesla's autonomous vehicle testing. The Department of Transportation and the Department of Motor Vehicles require a driver, testing without a driver, and driverless deployment.

Tesla holds a permit for testing autonomous vehicles with a human safety operator behind the wheel. It doesn't have a permit for driverless testing or deployment. And as of Wednesday it had not yet applied for additional permits, according to the DMV. (Mercedes-Benz, Nuro, and Waymo are the only three companies that hold driverless deployment permits.)

Nor does Tesla have the proper permits from the California Public Utilities Commission, which

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regulates the commercial aspects of ride-hailing and chartered transportation by humans as well as those steered by autonomous vehicle systems.

Tesla has a Transportation Charter Party permit, which allows a human driver to drive a traditional vehicle (not an AV) for charter services with the public, CPUC spokesperson Terrie Prosper told TechCrunch in an email.

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This is distinctly different from an autonomous vehicle permit for passenger transportation, according to Prosper. So-called AV authorizations, which Tesla doesn't have, allows for the testing and deployment of autonomous vehicles with or without a driver.

Tesla has not received approval from the CPUC to offer autonomous passenger service to customers, paid or unpaid, with or without a driver (nor has the company applied), Prosper explained in the email. Tesla also doesn't hold a "Drivered Pilot AV permit" from the CPUC, so it cannot even use an

autonomous vehicle with a human operator behind the wheel for passenger service.

This means that if Tesla deploys its robotaxis and the autonomous systems are engaged it will be violating state regulations even if the rides are free and there is a human safety operator behind the wheel.

The push into California comes as the DMV is currently trying to [stop Tesla from selling vehicles](#) in the state as part of a years-long lawsuit over the promises the company has made about its cars' self-driving abilities. Tesla is also [currently on trial in a lawsuit](#) over deaths related to the use of its less-ca

Tesla has software. While the version 22, it's been years to

The service core and in the first car is a

While the service launched with around 10 vehicles, it's not clear how many Model Y SUVs are in operation in the city, nor is it clear how many times those safety operators have had to intervene.

That's a long way from the "general solution" that Musk said Tesla was working on for a decade. Musk was once so confident in the autonomous software Tesla was developing that he said it would take a car from Los Angeles to New York — a stunt that never happened. Musk said this week that Tesla is also trying to expand to Florida and Arizona. TechCrunch [reported earlier this month](#) that Tesla

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had begun the required certification process to test and operate with and without a driver in Arizona.

Update: This story has been updated to include new information from the CPUC.

Topics: [robotaxi](#) [Tesla](#) [Transportation](#)



Sean O'Kane

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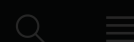
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Kirsten Korosec — 2:39 PM PDT · March 18, 2025

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Tesla was granted a transportation charter permit, or TCP. A TCP means the company — in this case Tesla — owns the vehicles and uses employees as drivers, according to the CPUC, which regulates human-driven and driverless ride-hailing services in the state. A TCP is for companies that want to offer prearranged transportation services like roundtrip sightseeing, according to the commission.

Uber and Lyft hold transportation network company (TNC) permits. TNCs use an online-enabled application like a smartphone app to connect

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drivers using their personal vehicles with paying passengers.

Tesla plans to initially use its TCP permit to transport employees on a prearranged basis and in vehicles owned by the automaker, according to its application. Tesla has agreed to notify the CPUC when it transitions to transporting members of the public.

Importantly, Tesla's application doesn't seek participation in the commission's Autonomous Vehicle Passenger Service Programs in either a drivered or driverless capacity. That doesn't mean Tesla won't eventually apply for those permits. If it

does, Tesla will seek approval from the California Public Utilities Commission, the state agency that regulates public utilities and dep

Tesla does not intend to use the permits to offer an on-demand ride-sharing service for purposes

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Tesla meanwhile is planning to launch a robotaxi service in Austin, Texas. Tesla CEO Elon Musk has promised the [robotaxi service](#) will begin in June using its own fleet vehicles that are equipped with the yet-to-be-released “unsupervised” version of its Full Self-Driving software.

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Tesla applies for ride-hail permit in California — but there's a catch

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Tesla applied for a permit with the California Public Utilities Commission (CPUC) to operate a transportation service in the state — a required first step in the process of launching a ride-hailing service.

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according to the CPUC, which regulates human-

driven and driverless ride-hailing services in the

state.

Uber and Lyft hold transportation network company

(TNC) permits. TNCs use an online-enabled

application like a smartphone app to connect

drivers using their personal vehicles with paying

passengers.

A CPUC spokesperson told TechCrunch that Tesla

has not applied for a TNC permit. The automaker

also has not applied to participate in the CPUC's

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Autonomous Vehicle Passenger Service program, the spokesperson said.

This doesn't mean Tesla isn't gearing up for a driverless ride-hailing service, though. According to the agency, companies must hold a TCP permit to participate in the autonomous vehicle passenger service program.

Tesla's application to operate in California runs counter to the automaker's shift away from the state for greener regulatory pastures like Texas.

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CEO Elon Musk said last month during an earnings call that his company would launch a [paid ride-hailing robotaxi service](#) in Austin this coming June. The service will use Tesla-owned vehicles — not those owned by individuals — and will use the yet-to-be-released “unsupervised” version of its Full Self-Driving software.

Musk also revealed last October a [purpose-built Cybercab prototype](#) designed without a steering

wheel or pedals.

Topics: [Lyft](#) [robotaxi](#) [Tesla](#) [Transportation](#) [Uber](#)



Kirsten Korosec

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Kirsten Korosec is a reporter and editor who has covered the future of transportation from EVs and autonomous...

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